

**OFFICE OF THE CHIEF ELECTORAL OFFICER
WEST BENGAL
21, N. S. ROAD, KOLKATA-700 001**

Memo No.3036(24) - Home (Elec)/R1M-06/2026

Dated, Kolkata, the 18th March, 2026

From: Additional Chief Electoral Officer,
West Bengal

To: District Election Officer,
All districts

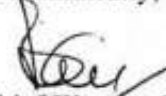
Subject: General Election to WBLA, 2026-SOP for voting through postal ballot for Absentee voters in the category of persons employed in essential services (AVES)-reg.

Madam/Sir,

In connection with the subject cited above, I am directed to state that a Standard Operating Procedure has been made for voting through postal ballot for absentee voters in the category of persons employed in essential services (AVES) to be followed in the ongoing General Elections to WBLA, 2026

In view of this, I am directed to request you to kindly bring the said SOP regarding voting through postal ballot for Absentee voters in respect of voting of certain classes of persons during General Elections to WBLA, 2026 for all concerned for further necessary action.

Yours faithfully,



Additional Chief Electoral Officer
West Bengal

**SOP for Voting through postal ballot for Absentee voters in the category of persons employed
in essential services [AVES]**

1. Applicability- persons employed in the following essential services in West Bengal:

1. Metro
2. Railway transport (passenger and freight) services
3. State Milk Union and Milk Cooperative Societies
4. Health Department
5. Road Transport Corporation
6. Fire services
7. Traffic Police
8. Jail
9. Excise
10. Treasury Services
11. Information and Public relation Department
12. Ambulance Services
13. Police
14. Civil Defence and Home Guards
15. Food Civil Supplies
16. Power
17. Department of PWD
18. All India Radio
19. Doordarshan

2. Role of the Department:

The departments of the notified category of electors will nominate "Nodal Officer" for the purpose of the postal ballot facility to such electors. If requires, more number of Nodal Officer may be appointed by the concerned department for the convenience of electors and better coordination with concerned Returning Officer/Assistant Returning Officer. The details of Nodal officers have to be communicated immediately to Chief Elector Officer, West Bengal via ceowbelection@gmail.com with a copy to concerned Returning Officer.

3. Role of Nodal Officer:

Copies of Form 12D appended to the Conduct of Elections Rules, 1961 has been made available to the Nodal Officer. Nodal Officer should inform the electors concerned about the facility. The Nodal officers will attest the Part II of Application Form (12D). One blank Form 12D is annexed herewith (Annexure 1). The Nodal Officer will also share the Postal Voting Centre (PVC) details to the electors once he is communicated by RO/ARO.

4. Timeline for application of Form 12D:

The Form 12D can be distributed at any time to the concerned electors after the announcement of election. The filled-up Form 12D along with required documents must reach the RO/ARO within the period of 5 days following the date of the notification of that phase. Phase wise last date of application of Form 12D is given in Annexure 2

5. Role of elector:

The concerned elector has to fill up Part I of Form 12D and get it attested by the concerned Nodal Officer in Part II. He has to submit the filled up attested Form 12D along with copy of EPIC card to the RO/ARO of his/her Assembly Constituency. The copy of the Identity card / accreditation card carrying the proof of his / her service may also be annexed along with EPIC.

The elector has to cast his/her vote at Postal Voting centre on the scheduled date as will be communicated by the RO/ARO showing EPIC.

6. Role of Returning Officer/ Assistant Returning Officer:

On receipt of application from "AVES"- Returning Officer / ARO —in-Charge will-

- a) Scrutinize the electoral particulars of the applicant/ elector
- b) If found correct, list of eligible AVES - in **Annexure-9** (List on the basis of which issue of postal ballot will be made)
- c) "PB" marking on the Electoral Roll- authentication of marking
- d) will intimate the eligible electors - the full address of the Postal Voting Centre venue where postal ballot voting is to be arranged; dates on which the postal ballot voting facility will remain open; the hours fixed for postal ballot voting by SMS to the telephone no. in the Application (12D) or through the BLO. The information should be disseminated through the Nodal Officer of the department/ Organisation concerned and advertisements in local newspapers.
- e) Set up Postal Voting Centre (PVC) at RO head quarter on three consecutive days at least 3 days before poll day. The PVC will function from 9AM to 5 PM.
- f) Intimate to the Contesting Candidates in writing regarding the schedule and provision of appointment of Polling Agents in Form 10 for watching the proceeding.
- g) Appoint 2-3 nos. of staff for polling at PVC and one Group Officer for attesting 13A declaration
- h) Arrangement of poll at PVC, custody of the documents and Ballot papers etc.

7. Role of District Election Officer: Publish the details of voting arrangement of AVES in the official website of the District Election Officer.

8. Materials required at PVC -

- i. Sufficient number of postal ballot papers,
- ii. Sufficient number of Form 13A (Declaration). Forms 13B envelope for Ballot and 13C envelope (Outer cover), 12D (Instruction);
- iii. Pen for marking vote;
- iv. Glue for closing the envelopes;
- v. RO facsimile and Ink-pad;
- vi. Box in which the envelopes containing marked ballot paper is to be dropped;

- vii. Register for obtaining signatures of electors on issue of ballot paper (**Annexure 10**)
- viii. List of Absentee Voters assigned for voting in the PVC with three extra copies (**Annexure-12**)
- ix. Format in **Annexure-13** for recording attendance of Polling Agents.
- X. Material for setting up voting compartment;
- xi. Large envelopes for sending the ballots after voting and the counterfoils of ballot papers to the RO on a daily basis;
- xii. Furniture for the polling staff, agents of candidates and for setting up voting compartment
- xiii. Indelible ink
- xiv. Other stationary items that would be required;

9. Voting Procedure

The process of voting at PB Facilitation centre is as follows:

1st PO — will identify by EPIC/other ECI -approved photo identity document and will take signature in register;

2nd PO- will apply indelible ink on left hand's forefinger;

3rd PO- will issue Postal Ballot, 13A, 13B, 13C and 13D;

- 13 A will be attested at Facilitation after verifying the EPIC card of the elector.
- After receiving of Postal Ballot, the elector has to write the postal Ballot number on 13B and 13 A. Polling Personnel has to mark 'X' (cross) / ✓ (tick) in favour of candidate of his /her choice after entering into voting compartment maintaining secrecy. After casting votes, the ballot has to be folded and put in 13B envelope & sealed. The sealed 13B and 13A have to be placed within 13C and has to be sealed and dropped in drop box.
- The representative of recognized political parties and contesting candidates will remain present.
- Whole process will be video -graphed.
- Signature of ARO/Polling Officer- back side of ballot paper and counter foil
- Noting Part No. and Serial No. of AVES- in the counterfoil of ballot paper.

10. Activities after each day Voting:

After the day poll closes: - the envelopes in Form 13C in the drop box shall be taken out, and sealed in a larger packet superscribed "Postal Ballots in PVC". On the outer packet, the following particulars should be clearly mentioned:

- Name and number of Constituency,
- Name of location of PVC,
- The date on which the votes were cast,
- The number of envelopes in form 13C in the packet.

The counterfoils of postal ballots shall also be sealed in a separate packet superscribed "Counter foils of PBs in PVC". Name and number of constituency and the dates on which it is sealed shall also be entered on such packet.

Both the packets containing the polled postal ballots and the counterfoils shall be sent to the Returning Officer in the same evening.

Signature of the agents of candidates present in the PVC should be obtained on each day of voting in the PVC. The format for this purpose is given at **Annexure- 13**.

At the end of the three days voting period, all other material supplied to the PVC shall be collected by the ARO in charge of the PVC and retained at the headquarters as per standard protocol for the material concerned.

If an Absentee Voter does not turn up for voting in the PVC, there is no requirement for sending the postal ballot to him/her by post. The Procedure prescribed for postal voting by them in the PVC and in no other manner.

11. Relevant Registers/Forms:

Annexure -1: Blank 12D

Annexure-2: Schedule of receiving of Form 12D & Functioning of PVC

Annexure -9: List AVES whose 12D Form has been received - by RO

Annexure -10: Register of AVES voters - by Poll Officer

Annexure-11: Declaration of Companion - by Poll officer

Annexure-12: List of AVES whom PB to be issued - by RO

Annexure-13: Signature of agents - by presiding officer

Annexure -14: Statement of PB by RO

Annexure II

Details of election dates

Events	Phase 1	Phase 2
No. of ACs	152 ACs (16 districts)	142 ACs (8 districts)
Dates of Nominations	30.03.2026 (Monday) - 06.04.2026 (Monday)	02.04.2026 (Thursday) - 09.04.2026 (Thursday)
Distribution & receiving of filled up 12D for Absentee PB/AVSC, AVPD	By 04.04.2026 (Saturday)	By 07.04.2026 (Tuesday)
Functioning of AVES PB Postal voting centre at RO Head Quarter	<u>17-19.04.2026</u>	<u>23-25.04.2026</u>

Date of Poll.

23rd April

25th April.

2:30 (PM)
~~- DELHA -~~
 - 2M (5) ✓
 PSC (1M) ✓
 - WBSE7CL ✓
 - DPL (1) ✓

2M (8) WBSE7CL
 ↓
RO

FORM 12D

[see rule 27-C]

PART I

Letter of intimation to Assistant Returning Officer
(for absentee voters)

To

The Assistant Returning Officer,
(for the notified class of electors)

..... Parliamentary/Assembly constituency
..... (designation and address of ARO)

Sir,

I, son/daughter/wife of
resident of village/mohalla
Town/city/tehsil District (State) belong to the class of
absentee voter and wish to cast my vote by post at the election to the House of the People/Legislative Assembly
from the Parliamentary/Assembly constituency.

My complete present postal address is as under:-

House/dwelling unit/tent number

Camp/mohalla/village

Ward/town/tehsil

District

State

PIN CODE

Mobile Phone No. (if available)

My name is entered at serial number in Part No. of the
electoral roll for Parliamentary/Assembly constituency.

I am working as (designation of the office held) in

(Name and full address of organization).

I will be on duty in the above-mentioned office on the day of poll for the above-mentioned election.

* On account of my official duties on the date of poll, I will not be in a position to be present in the polling station assigned to me on the day of poll.

Or

* I am years of age/ am a person with disability, and am not in a position to go to the polling station to cast vote.

It is requested that postal ballot paper may be issued to me as absentee voter for the above election.

Yours faithfully,

.....
(Full name and signature)

PART II

(for absentee voter other than senior citizen or persons with disability)

Certificate by the nodal officer appointed by the Organization concerned.

It is hereby certified that the particulars given by the applicant in Part I are correct, and it is further certified that the applicant will be on official duty on the day of poll, and he/she will not be in a position to be present in the polling station on the day of poll.

.....
(full signature of the attesting Officer)

..... (Name)

..... (address)

..... (rubber stamp)

- Strike off whichever is not applicable and tick the relevant statement.

Note— This Application must reach RO within 5 days following the date of notification of election.